The Little Ink Box

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 6

Nib checked the ferry rope. He checked where it met the post. Then he gave the knot a small, thoughtful tug.

“Rope on. Mouse remaining,” Nib declared firmly.

Your map was dry inside its folio. The original section and two recovered pieces rested on their stiff backing. Lark carried the explorer case aboard while Nib settled the wagon on the deck. Nobody untied the rope until everyone was ready.

The ferry crossed quietly to the island. This time Nib stayed beside the rail. At the island landing, Lark looped the rope over a broad post before anyone stepped onto the dry bank.

Under a low shelter stood the little ink box shown on your map. Its lid was shut. Beside it were a sturdy bench and a brass tapping plate. A rod joined the bench to a small counterweight beneath the box.

Nib tried the handle. The lid stayed closed.

“Very determined ink,” Nib observed cautiously.

Lark brushed dust from an instruction strip. An old black drip spread across its edge. She leaned closer, then sighed.

“I think the ink has hidden the clue,” Lark admitted ruefully.

Nib peered beneath the drip. Two little words stood clear. An arrow ran between them.

“It left the sitting bit,” Nib observed with interest.

Lark took out the journal's practice strip. First she showed a familiar word from your map-pocket adventure.

“Try this one before we look at the new clue,” Lark invited gently. “Read tap. You can take its sounds slowly.”

She drew a short line and put a dot above it.

“Here is lowercase i,” Lark explained clearly. “It makes the short sound at the start of ink: /i/. A quick, relaxed sound. Listen to short a, then short i. Find i beside a.”

Nib kept his paws on the dry bench while Lark set s and t on either side of the new letter. She joined the sounds into sit. Then she changed i to a, making sat.

“The outside letters stay the same,” Lark explained softly. “Listen to the middle. Sit. Sat. Join sit with me, then try the other word.”

The bench looked increasingly inviting to Nib.

“A promising instruction,” Nib murmured hopefully.

Before they tested it, Lark opened the ink-box journal page.

“Write our little i here,” Lark invited warmly. “A short line down, then lift your finger and add its dot. Keep it beside our picture of the ink drip.”

On the real instruction strip, the first word stood above the bench. The second stood above the brass plate. The arrow showed their order.

“Read the two words from left to right,” Lark encouraged gently. “Which job comes first?”

Nib followed the first instruction. He sat on the bench. It lowered a small, safe distance on its pivot. Beneath the box, the counterweight rose into place. The brass plate moved free of its stop.

“Now read the next word,” Lark invited softly. “Use its instruction on the plate.”

With a small tap, the catch clicked. The lid lifted on its hinge and stayed braced above the box.

Inside lay the third missing map section, wrapped in dry cloth. Beside it was a little ink stamp for the journal.

“A splendid box,” Nib declared appreciatively. “It understands sitting down.”

Lark added the new section beside the others. The moonstone revealed a narrow path toward a meadow, with a nest drawn beside the bank. Only one space in the old map remained empty.

She pressed the stamp onto your ink-box page and drew the bench beneath it.

“What made the catch ready for our tap?” Lark asked gently. “Think about the empty bench and the bench after Nib sat down.”

Lark looked again at the old drip. It had covered part of the strip, but not the words they needed.

“Thank you for looking underneath,” Lark told Nib warmly. “I nearly stopped looking.”

Nib rose. The bench returned to its resting place. Lark packed the paper and stamp, and everyone boarded the ferry before the island rope came loose. Back at the ordinary dock, they tied it safely again.

Ahead waited the dry nesting bank. Behind you, the little box was closed, the island was quiet, and all four of your map sections were safe.